

AI receptionist for a small business: what it is, what it costs, what to test

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AI receptionist for a small business: what it is, what it costs, what to test

By Dillon Mohr, Momentum Digital, Philadelphia

An AI receptionist is software that answers your phone, asks the caller what they need, captures a name and number, and either books, routes or takes a message. It costs a monthly fee plus usage. The price matters less than the test: thirty real call scenarios, scored, before it ever talks to a customer.

Here's how to think about it if you run a shop with a phone that rings more than it gets answered.

What does an AI receptionist actually do?

People use "AI answering" to mean four different things. Sort them before you buy.

- **Receptionist.** Picks up the call. Talks. Captures who's calling and why. Books or takes a message.
- **Missed-call text-back.** Doesn't pick up. Sends a text to the number you missed. Cheapest of the four.
- **Router.** Takes what came in from any source and moves it to the right person or system with the right label.
- **Agent.** Reads the request, decides what it needs, drafts a reply, and asks a person before sending.

Most vendors sell the first and imply the other three. Ask which one you're buying.

Does a small business need one?

The demand says people think so. "AI receptionist" gets about 12,100 searches per month in the US, and the trend went from 3,600 a month in August 2025 to 90,500 by July 2026. "AI receptionist for small business" is around 1,600 a month, up from zero two years ago. The page-one results are a phone vendor, a Reddit thread, then RingCentral, GoTo, Smith.ai and a few startups. All vendors, plus one forum.

Here's the number that made me take it seriously. On our own agency's tracked phone line in July 2026, through the 27th, we had 263 inbound calls. 101 were answered. 162 were missed. A 38.4% answer rate. And zero percent of those calls had an owner assigned in the CRM.

I'm not telling you that to sell you something. I'm telling you because if your answer rate looks like ours did, you need something. Maybe not an AI. Maybe a text-back and a person who owns the callback. Start with the number.

What does it cost?

I'm not going to quote vendor prices. They change monthly and I'd be wrong by the time you read this.

The structure is what matters. Expect a monthly platform fee, usage billed per minute or per call, sometimes a setup fee, and sometimes an integration fee to connect it to your booking tool or CRM. Ask five questions before you sign:

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1. What's the all-in monthly cost at my actual call volume?
 2. What happens to the caller when it fails? Voicemail, a person, or a dropped call?
 3. What does it log, and can I export the log?
 4. Does it write into my CRM or booking tool, or does it just email me?
 5. Can I turn it off in one click?

Then compare the answer to the cost of a missed call in your trade. You know that number better than any vendor does.

What should I test before it talks to a customer?

This is the part vendors skip and the part that matters.

Write 30 named scenarios. Real ones from your own phone log. Ten to get you started:

1. After-hours emergency.
2. Existing customer asking about an appointment already booked.
3. Wrong number.
4. Sales solicitation.
5. A price question.
6. Caller gives half a phone number and stops.
7. Caller hangs up mid-sentence.
8. Caller speaks Spanish.
9. Caller asks for a person by name.
10. Angry caller with a complaint.

Run every one. Score each as pass or fail. The bar we use for our own lead-operations work, and the bar I'd hold any vendor to:

- At least 95% of the 30 scenarios pass.
- 100% of the accepted records land in the destination system and read back correctly. Not "it said it saved". Go look.
- The person who'll own it runs five of the cases themselves, supervised.
- Every failure is written down with a name next to it and a fix.

Don't go live until all four are true. If a vendor won't sit through that test, that's your answer.

What must it never say?

It must never claim it did something it hasn't done yet.

Our own website chatbot got this wrong in August 2026. It told a visitor "I have routed this to the Momentum 360 team" before it had captured an email address. The ticket landed in the CRM with no owner, because the assignment rule only assigned to people marked available, and everyone was marked away. The visitor was told they'd been handed off. Nobody had them.

We moved the email capture ahead of the handoff, removed the availability rule so tickets always land on someone, and rewrote the message so it claims a send only after the send happened. Then we tested it and watched the ticket land.

The rule: the machine says what it did, not what it intends to do. And it doesn't promise a callback window a human isn't staffed to keep. Business-hours acknowledgment is honest. "We'll call you back in ten minutes" at 2 AM is a lie with a friendly voice.

Which tools fit a field-service shop?

Disclosure first: Momentum is a Jobber partner. So weigh that.

For trades, the practical choices are the receptionist built into your field-service platform if it offers one (people search for Jobber's by name), an all-in-one like HighLevel, or the receptionist add-on from your phone system. I'm not going to rank them. Compare them on two things only: what they log about every call, and where they write it. A receptionist that books beautifully but leaves the record in its own app is a second inbox you'll stop checking.

FAQ

Will callers know it's an AI? Assume yes, and have it say so. Most callers care more about being called back than about who picked up.

Can an AI receptionist book jobs directly? Some can, if connected to your booking tool. Test that connection in the 30 cases. The handoff between the receptionist and the calendar is where they fail.

Is this the same as missed-call text-back? No. Text-back is one automatic text after a missed call. A receptionist answers. Text-back is cheaper and is often the right first step.

The next step

If you want a second pair of eyes on your phone before you buy anything, I'll do a 15-minute snapshot: three observations about how calls reach you, with the evidence for each, and one suggested next step. Free. No deck, no pitch. Reach me through needmomentum.com.

Momentum built the machine. Now we build yours.